



almost nothing to draw attention to itself, the building nevertheless achieves an understated elegance. It is also an astonishing piece of engineering. Raised off the ground, it is supported only by two narrow piers, to provide access to an apartment building on its far side. These piers not only support the entire building, but the cantilevered structure they carry means that every one of the building's seven floors is entirely open plan. The result is a structure of deceptive simplicity.

Pirelli Tower

Location Milan, Italy

The Pirelli Tower was designed by Italian architect Gio Ponti and engineer Pier Luigi. Built in 1955–1958, it dramatically expanded the meaning of skyscrapers. This was

partly because, at 417 ft (127 m), it was in some way the tallest building in Italy, but also partly due to its shape. In contrast to the rectilinear high-rises being built in the US, the ends of the Pirelli Tower taper, forming, in effect, a wing-shaped building. It is a visual device of elegance, reinforced by a secondary roof that appears to float over the 32-story structure. The building inspired the design of the Pan Am building (now, MetLife Building) in New York, among others.

Olympic Stadium, Munich

Location Munich, Germany

Munich's Olympic Stadium, built for the 1972 games by German architects Günter Behnisch and

Otto Frei, was the most revolutionary and instantly recognizable sports stadium built at the time. The architects used rigorous mathematics and computer-aided design to determine its structure and flowing shape. To a large extent, the aim was to avoid the kind of monumental, stone-built stadium used for the Berlin games in 1936. By extension, it was also intended that the 1972 games would be a means of demonstrating to the world that West Germany had put its Nazi past behind it. The solution was a stadium set into the ground rather than rising out of it. Its partial roof of rising and falling translucent, tentlike acrylic panels is supported by eight steel pylons and braced by 271 miles (436 km) of steel cabling. Although now transformed into a movie theater and performance venue, it remains a memorable location.

Lloyd's Building

Location London, England

When it opened in 1986, Richard Rogers's building for insurers Lloyd's instantly established itself as the most innovative building in London. The impact of this extraordinary, almost sculptural, steel structure has never lessened. Its most obvious feature is that all of its vital systems are placed on the outside; its three main towers are covered with pipes, ducts, vents, cabling, and glass-fronted elevators. Similarly, a series of cranes, used for cleaning, stud the roofs. Not only does this make repairs easier, it creates space inside. The most dominant internal feature is the glass-vaulted atrium rising the full 289-ft (88-m) height of the building, criss-crossed with escalators. There are 14 floors of office space around it.